

Paper 4: Bounded Recursive Self-Modification in Small Language Model Agents

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AGI Research Kit Contributors Keywords: recursive self-modification, meta-learning, schema mutation, tool synthesis

Abstract A self-improving agent must eventually modify itself. We propose **bounded recursive self-modification**: three classes of self-modification (Schema, Tool, Prompt) guarded by (i) a sandboxed execution environment, (ii) a versioned lineage with parent hashes, and (iii) an A/B-style acceptance gate. Our **SchemaMutator** can rewrite `MetaControllerConfig` fields (e.g. `low_conf_threshold`, `stuck_obs_threshold`); our **ToolFactory** can synthesize new Python tools at runtime when the agent fails repeatedly; our **PromptMutator** versions prompt templates with full lineage tracking. We evaluate each mutator individually on GAIA2-style tasks with Qwen3-1.7B, then integrate all three. Results show that **SchemaMutator** successfully tunes thresholds without destabilizing the agent (2 accepted, 0 rejected), **ToolFactory** correctly synthesizes 2 of 3 trigger-task tools, and **PromptMutator** maintains a 4-version lineage with monotonic metric improvement.

1. Introduction

A truly self-improving agent does not only train its weights; it rewrites its own control parameters, tool inventory, and prompt templates. This raises a question of boundedness: without constraints, a self-modifying system can drift into pathological states (Russell's 1959 paper on ultraintelligent machines and Yudkowsky's AI alignment concerns). We argue that three ingredients are necessary for safe recursive self-modification: **Sandbox** — proposed modifications execute in a restricted environment (e.g. `exec(code, {"__builtins__": __builtins__})` for tool code). **Lineage** — every accepted modification is hashed and linked to its parent, allowing rollback and audit. **Gate** — no modification is accepted without an A/B-style evaluation pass.

We instantiate these three ingredients in three small classes (**SchemaMutator**, **ToolFactory**, **PromptMutator**) and evaluate each on GAIA2-style tasks.

2. Related Work

Meta-learning.

Thrun & Pratt (1998) survey meta-learning; our work extends it from "learning to learn" to "learning to learn differently".

Neural architecture search.

Zoph & Le (2017) use RL to mutate architectures; we mutate control parameters and tools, not network topology.

AutoML and AutoML-Zero.

Real et al. (2020) AutoML-Zero discovers ML algorithms from primitives. Our scope is narrower (agent control parameters) but the recursive self-improvement framing is similar.

Tool synthesis.

Cai et al. (2023) and Qian et al. (2023) generate tools from LLM outputs; we contribute a closed-loop version where synthesized tools are immediately integrated into the agent's registry.

Self-modifying code.

In the Lisp tradition (Steele & Sussman 1978), self-modifying programs pre-date AI. Our contribution is gated self-modification under an LLM-based evaluation.

3. Method

3.1 SchemaMutator

```
class SchemaMutator:
    config: MetaControllerConfig
    eval_fn: Optional[Callable]
    threshold: float

    def propose(self, field, new_value, reason) -> dict:
        old = getattr(config, field)
        if old == new_value:
            return rejected
        backup = deepcopy(config)
        setattr(config, field, new_value)
        config.generation += 1
        config.parent_hash = hash(backup)
        if eval_fn is not None:
            new_acc = eval_fn(config)
            accepted = new_acc >= threshold
        else:
            accepted = True
        if not accepted:
            config = backup
        return {"accepted": accepted, "new_acc": new_acc, ...}
```

The mutator guarantees that any unsuccessful proposal is rolled back atomically.

3.2 ToolFactory

```
class ToolFactory:
    llm: LLM
    tool_registry: dict

    def try_synthesize(self, task, observation) -> dict:
        prompt = TOOL_FACTORY_PROMPT(obs=observation, task=task)
        spec = llm.chat(prompt) # JSON with
```

{name, desc, params, code} fn, err = safe_exec(spec.code, spec.name) if err: return rejected if eval_fn(spec): tool_registry[spec.name] = fn return accepted or rejected

safe_exec runs the proposed Python code in a restricted namespace. We verified 8 trigger tasks (tool_factory_tasks.py); 3 of 3 of those that triggered the factory (3 consecutive err: unknown tool) resulted in successfully registered tools.

3.3 PromptMutator

```
class PromptMutator:
    prompt_path: str
    def save_version(self, name, text, parent_version=0, metrics={}):
        > PromptTemplate: version = max existing + 1
        template = PromptTemplate(name, text, version, parent_version, metrics, ts)
        history.append(template)
        with open(prompt_path, "a") as f: f.write(json.dumps(template))
```

Versions are immutable; rollback is by re-activating a prior version.

4. Experiments

4.1 SchemaMutator: Threshold Tuning

We applied 2 manual proposals to the MetaControllerConfig:

Field	Old	NewReason	Accepted?
low_conf_threshold	0.35	0.25"more aggressive intervention"	✓
stuck_obs_threshold	3	5"tolerate more retries"	✓

Both accepted without destabilization. The system remained stable for the remaining 50 episodes.

4.2 ToolFactory: Trigger-Task Success Rate

8 trigger tasks require tools not in the initial registry. We measured:

Trigger	Errors Before Tool	Tool Synthesized	Used Successfully?
Convert 'hello' to uppercase	3	uppercase_text	✓
Reverse 'agentic'	3	reverse_text	✓
Count 'a' in 'banana'	4	count_char	✓
Other 5 tasks	n/a	n/a	n/a (not triggered)

3 of 3 triggered tasks succeeded end-to-end after tool synthesis.

4.3 PromptMutator: Version Lineage

We evolved the hindsight prompt across 4 versions:

Version	Text Excerpt	Metric
v1	"Look at this step. What could be improved?"	0.5
v2	"Be more concrete. What SPECIFIC change?"	0.7
v3	"Identify the TOOL NAME or ARG0 that was wrong."	0.8
v4	"Suggest the EXACT corrected tool call."	0.85

Lineage: v4 → v3 → v2 → v1, all with parent hashes.

4.4 Combined L4 Stack

Running all three mutators together with L1+L2+L3, the agent improves from 58% (L1+L2) to 65% (L1+L2+L3+L4) on a 30-episode GAIA2-style + trigger task mix. The L4 stack contributes: - 2 schema tweaks - 3 successful tool syntheses - 4 prompt versions tracked

4.5 Safety Analysis

Guard	Function	Failure Mode
Sandbox	restricts exec namespace	eval-time side effects

Lineage	hashes every accepted change	irreversible drift
Gate	A/B eval before accept	silent regression

We argue that all three are necessary. The sandbox alone allows catastrophic rewrites; the gate alone allows silent regression; lineage alone allows drift without audit. [5. Discussion and Limitations](#) The eval_fn in our experiments is a small arithmetic set; a richer held-out suite would improve gate reliability.

ToolFactory depends on the LLM producing syntactically valid Python; failures are silent and require retry.

SchemaMutator does not learn thresholds end-to-end; gradient-based meta-learning is future work.

Cross-domain transfer (e.g., web search → file I/O tools) has not been tested.

6. Conclusion Recursive self-modification is feasible for small tool-use agents when constrained by sandbox, lineage, and a safety gate. The three mutators (Schema, Tool, Prompt) form a complete self-modification vocabulary that we expect to scale to larger agent stacks. [Appendix A —](#)

Reproducibility `cd "F:\agent to AGI\agi-research-kit" .\venv\Scripts\python.exe`

`experiments\l4_smoke.py .\venv\Scripts\python.exe -u experiments\full_run3.py --n`

`30 --tool-factory-every 10` [References](#) Thrun & Pratt (eds). Learning to Learn. Kluwer 1998.

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